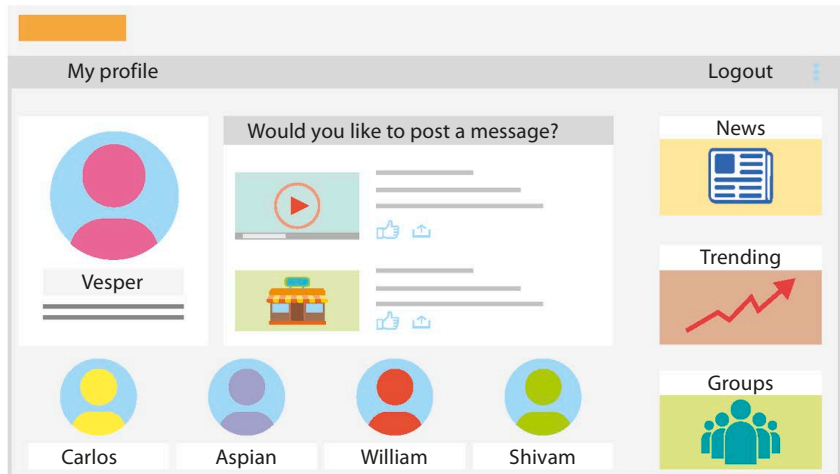


Using social networks

Social networks are some of the most popular ways people connect with friends and families. But just because everybody's using them doesn't mean caution isn't needed.

What do you get from a social network?

Social networks are places where you can meet new people and keep up to date with friends and family. They are also where we get a lot of our news, discover what's going on in our local area, and find new trends in things we find interesting. Some social networks are aimed at helping users find a job. Others are to help users find new friends. There are social networks online for pretty much anything and everything.



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◀ 178–179 Online and digital identities

◀ 194–195 What is social media?

IN DEPTH

Digital footprint

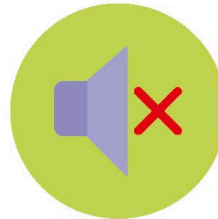
Everything you do on a social network is collected by the company who runs it. This information is called your digital footprint, and it is used by the company to show you information – such as ads – that might appeal to you. This footprint might be shared between companies, to create an even more detailed profile of you and your connections. This is a controversial thing, and governments around the world are grappling with the question of who should own a user's digital footprint data – the user, or the companies whose services they are using?

◀ Your profile

Your profile is the most important thing on your social network: it tells people who you are (or, what you want to tell them about who you are), and it shows your connections and content.

Managing relationships on social networks

As a user connects with more people, their social network expands. To make a connection, one person submits a request to connect with another. If it's accepted, the connection is made. But just like offline, it's important to maintain that connection – this might be by sharing information and responding to theirs, or creating content that's useful to other people. Social network connections can also be broken. If someone chooses to sever contact, their information won't be viewable by the other any more.



△ Muting

If someone uses social media a bit too much for your liking, you can often mute them. It doesn't stop them from saying things, but their posts will no longer be visible to you any more.



△ Unfriending

When a connection is disconnected, a user's content won't be published to a former friend's newsfeed. Sometimes the unfriended person may still see the other's content.